

Findings

Dataset: 246,745 Facebook ad purchases from the 2024 U.S. Presidential election, each mentioning one or more presidential candidates.

Spending is concentrated among a few large pages

Spending is heavily concentrated among a small number of pages. Based on the midpoint of each ad's reported spending range, the total advertising spend in the dataset is about \$262 million. Most of that spending comes from just a handful of advertisers - the top 10 pages alone account for around 63% of the total. The Kamala Harris campaign spent the most (about \$82.8 million), followed by Joe Biden (around \$26.4 million) and Donald J. Trump (about \$19.6 million).

Looking at individual ads, the average spend is \$1,061.79, while the median spend is only \$49.50. This tells us that although a few ads have very large budgets, most ads are relatively inexpensive. Because of these high-spending outliers, the median gives a more realistic picture of what a typical ad costs.

Spending rises sharply before the election

Spending increased steadily as the election approached. Weekly spending gradually rose from August through October 2024, before surging in the final two weeks leading up to the November 5 election. The week beginning October 27, 2024 recorded the highest spending at approximately \$36.4 million, which was more than three times the amount spent in any single week during September. This pattern suggests that campaigns significantly increased their advertising efforts just before Election Day.

Trump and Harris are the most-mentioned candidates

Donald Trump is the most frequently mentioned candidate in the dataset. In the illuminating_mentions column, Donald Trump appears in 53,182 ads, making him the most commonly mentioned candidate, followed by Kamala Harris. However, around 73,205 ads do not mention any candidate by name in this field, even though all of the ads are related to the presidential election. This suggests that the illuminating_mentions column does not fully capture the subject of every ad and should not be used as the only source for identifying which candidate an ad is about.

Data quality note

A few data quality issues were identified during the analysis. The `ad_delivery_stop_time` column contains 2,159 missing values, which may affect analyses involving ad duration or end dates. In addition, candidate names are not always recorded consistently. For example, "Donald Trump" and "President Trump" appear as separate values, even though they refer to the same person. Because of these inconsistencies, simply counting the frequency of each name can underestimate the total number of times a candidate is mentioned.